

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Sales of existing homes** rose in November, notching the biggest annual gain in more than three years after a greater supply of homes for sale gave buyers more opportunities. **A1**
- ◆ **The U.S. economy** grew more than initially estimated in the third quarter, extending a solid stretch of economic expansion. **A2**
- ◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** stabilized but failed to hold on to early gains, leaving the S&P 500 down less than 0.1% at the close. The Nasdaq fell 0.1% and the Dow rose less than 0.1%. **B9**
- ◆ **Thousands of Amazon** workers went on strike during the run-up to Christmas over contract negotiations and the company's refusal to recognize the Teamsters labor union. **B1**
- ◆ **FedEx will spin off** its freight trucking division, moving to streamline its structure and unlock value that some shareholders argue has been lost at the delivery service. **B1**
- ◆ **The Walton family** passed some of its control of Walmart to the next generation, giving all the grandchildren of Walmart's founder voting rights over their inheritance. **B1**
- ◆ **Apple called out** Meta Platforms for trying to gain access to key software tools on iPhones, saying it was concerned companies might try to abuse an EU law to access sensitive user data. **B4**
- ◆ **The Bank of England** left its key interest rate unchanged at 4.75% a day after the Fed rocked markets by signaling fewer cuts in the year ahead. **A7**
- ◆ **Lamb Weston replaced** its chief executive and again cut guidance as demand for frozen potato products falters. **B1**

World-Wide

- ◆ **House Republicans'** slimmed-down plan to try to avert a government shutdown was defeated in a hastily called vote, as several dozen GOP lawmakers joined with Democrats in rejecting the proposal endorsed by Trump. **A1, A4**
- ◆ **Immigrants accounted** for 84% of U.S. population growth in the year ended June 30, the Census Bureau said, extending a trend since the Covid-19 pandemic. **A1**
- ◆ **China allowed** European investigators to board the ship suspected of sabotaging two data cables in the Baltic Sea on the condition that Chinese officials accompany them. **A7**
- ◆ **The FAA issued** a month-long ban on flying drones in parts of New Jersey for security reasons after a string of unexplained drone sightings in the region. **A3**
- ◆ **A Georgia appeals court** removed Fulton County District Attorney Fani Willis from her election-interference prosecution against Trump and other defendants, citing her romantic relationship with a deputy. **A6**
- ◆ **Russian President** Vladimir Putin appeared in no hurry to seek an end to the war in Ukraine during his annual set-piece television event. **A8**
- ◆ **Israeli airstrikes** shook Yemen's rebel-held capital and a port city, killing at least nine people, officials said, shortly after a Houthi missile targeted central Israel. **A8**
- ◆ **Andrew Cuomo** filed a court document indicating he plans to sue one of the women who accused him of sexual harassment while he was governor of New York. **A2**

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CEO Shooting Suspect Could Face Death Penalty



FEDERAL CASE: Luigi Mangione, arriving Thursday in New York from Pennsylvania, appeared in federal court on murder and stalking charges in the slaying of health-insurance executive Brian Thompson. Prosecutors could seek the death penalty. **A3**

White House Made Adjustments For an Aging, Diminished Biden

During the 2020 presidential primary, Jill Biden campaigned so extensively across Iowa that she held events in more counties than her husband—a fact

By Annie Linskey, Rebecca Ballhaus, Emily Glazer and Siobhan Hughes

her press secretary at the time, Michael LaRosa, touted to a local reporter.

His superior in the Biden campaign quickly chided him. As the three rode in a minivan through the state's cornfields, Anthony Bernal, then a deputy

campaign manager and chief of staff to Jill Biden, pressed LaRosa to contact the reporter again and play down any comparison in campaign appearances between Joe Biden, then 77, and his wife, who is eight years his junior. Her energetic schedule only highlighted her husband's more plodding pace, LaRosa recalls being told.

The message from Biden's team was clear. "The more you talk her up, the more you make him look bad," LaRosa said.

The small correction foreshadowed how Biden's closest aides and advisers would manage the limitations of the oldest

president in U.S. history during his four years in office.

To adapt the White House around the needs of a diminished leader, they told visitors to keep meetings focused. Interactions with senior Democratic lawmakers and some cabinet members—including powerful secretaries such as Defense's Lloyd Austin and Treasury's Janet Yellen—were infrequent or grew less frequent. Some legislative leaders had a hard time getting the president's ear at key moments, including ahead of the U.S.'s disastrous pullout from Afghanistan.

Senior advisers were often

put into roles that some administration officials and lawmakers thought Biden should occupy, with people such as National Security Adviser Jake Sullivan, senior counselor Steve Ricchetti and National Economic Council head Lael Brainard and her predecessor frequently in the position of being go-betweens for the president.

Press aides who compiled packages of news clips for Biden were told by senior staff to exclude negative stories about the president. The president wasn't talking to his own pollsters as surveys showed him trailing in

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GOP Plan To Avoid Shutdown Defeated In House

Dozens in the party rebel against bill that Trump backed after he killed budget deal

WASHINGTON—House Republicans' slimmed-down plan to try to avert a government shutdown was defeated in a hastily called vote Thursday, as several dozen GOP lawmakers joined with Democrats in rejecting the proposal endorsed by President-elect Donald Trump.

The revised legislation proposed extending government

By Lindsay Wise, Katy Stech Ferek and Siobhan Hughes

funding for three months and providing more than \$100 billion in disaster relief and aid for farmers, while stripping out a series of other provisions, such as restrictions on investments in China, 9/11 healthcare funds and new rules on pharmacy-benefit managers. It also proposed suspending the nation's borrowing limit for two years.

It had 174 votes in favor and 235 against, with one member voting present, well short of the two-thirds majority required under special fast-track procedures. Crucially, it also was shy of a simple majority of the GOP-controlled chamber, dimming its chances of being brought to the floor again and marking an embarrassing setback for both Trump and embattled House Speaker Mike

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- ◆ **Musk's clout on show** in spending-bill feud..... **A4**
- ◆ **Effects of shutdown** would be widespread..... **A4**

Rape Sentences Spur Outrage



BACKLASH: Gisèle Pelicot leaves court in Avignon, France, after her ex-husband and 50 other men were convicted in a rape trial. Relatively light sentences sparked anger. **A7**

The Top-Secret Gift Shop You Need Clearance to Enter

Federal buildings house a network of stores most people will never see; CIA pillows

By SADIE GURMAN

LANGLEY, Va.—Looking for the holiday gift that screams Beltway insider?

Skip the chintzy T-shirt vendors on the National Mall and head straight to the CIA. Just be ready to provide your Social Security number and leave enough time to clear multiple layers of security. And bring cash. The agency advises against using traceable forms of payment like credit cards, particularly for customers who do undercover work.

Inside the gift shop at the George Bush Center for Intelligence, customers can pick

from an assortment of intelligence-themed merchandise, like "Top Secret" barbecue sauce, "Don't Spill The Beans" coffee, CIA pillows and a \$200 humidor etched with the agency's iconic seal.

"There's something for every taste," said the shop's executive director Mark Wiggins as he strolled through the store, where a set of shot glasses emblazoned with "Admit Nothing. Deny Everything" sells for \$33.99. It isn't impossible to visit, but it is difficult: You either need to be a CIA employee or know one. Wiggins calls his operation

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Immigration Is Main Driver Of Population Growth in U.S.

Immigrants are having a huge impact on the nation's population growth, new federal estimates show.

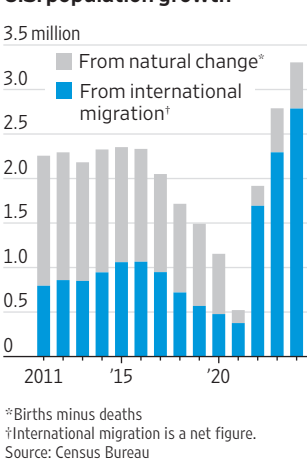
Newcomers accounted for 84% of U.S. growth in the year

By Jon Kamp, Paul Overberg, and Max Rust

ended June 30, the Census Bureau said Thursday, continuing a trend since the Covid-19 pandemic. This was fueled by a surge in legal and illegal arrivals, a falling birthrate and a death rate propped up by an aging population.

The Census Bureau estimates include major revisions to earlier estimates that are intended to better capture a surge in immigration. The bureau estimates about 2.7 mil-

U.S. population growth



lion net arrivals for the most recent year. The bureau also more than doubled its net immigration estimate for the prior year to about 2.3 million.

The agency now estimates the U.S. grew by 8.5 million over the past four years, with immigrants accounting for the vast majority.

For the most recent year, through June 30, the bureau estimates that the U.S. population grew by about 1% to 340.1 million. This is the fastest growth since 2001, the bureau said.

Much of this growth came in states such as Texas (563,000) and Florida (467,000). Only three states were estimated to have lost population, and just barely: Vermont, West Virginia and Mississippi. The South accounted for 54% of the latest year's growth.

The bureau's numbers are the latest data point for fed-

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Blip Up in Home Sales Masks a Weak Year

By NICOLE FRIEDMAN

Sales of existing homes rose in November, notching the biggest year-over-year gain in more than three years after a bigger supply of homes for sale gave buyers more opportunities.

Even so, home-buying activity remains subdued for the second straight year. Sales of previously owned homes in 2024 are on track to hit their lowest level since 1995.

Home prices are still near record highs, and while a late-summer drop in mortgage rates helped give a boost to November sales, rates have returned to higher levels. Many would-be buyers are priced out of the market.

"With mortgage rates back

up to levels from last summer, sales activity is likely to wane again in coming months," said Ben Ayers, senior economist at Nationwide.

The inventory of homes for sale has been extremely low in recent years because homeowners haven't wanted to give up their low mortgage rates by selling and moving. But a rise in supply in recent months has been a rare bright spot. Inventory is up in part because some of those homeowners are getting impatient, especially if they have had a life change like a new baby or a job relocation.

The recent uptick in supply and sales offers hope that next year could be an improvement after this long pe-

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INSIDE



MANSION

When older couples move in together, it means melding styles, a lifetime of stuff. **M1**

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Nike is offering massive holiday discounts, but it's a risky strategy. **B1**